





VANITY FARE
(1, 2, 4) A water park, the Chambal Mata statue and a Jawaharlal Nehru mask at the Chambal riverfront; **(3)** the Maharana Pratap flyover, and **(5)** a ship replica in Kota

riverfront, is one of the many who fear that they will be displaced to make way for Dhariwal's plaster-of-Paris Kota.

Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat is even-handed in his critique. Last year, at a city college worn down by neglect, he said: "It's sad to see a city that has no rooms for students spending on statues of elephants and horses." The aforementioned state minister is equally trenchant. "Even a king would have thought twice before spending so much on cosmetic effects.... It's feudal raj at its best." He also cites questionable expenditure in Jaipur—say, a luxurious, 24-storey indoor patient facility being built for Rs 700 crore. But it's Kota that takes the cake, and at a time when Rajasthan isn't exactly awash in bread.

Rajasthan has a history of letting things go to waste, whether crumbling heritage structures or mega projects like the Dravyavati river restoration. The operative credo here can be expressed via a rhetorical question: suppose you, as a government, put in honest money into something begun by a different regime...who gets the credit? It's a no-brainer. It's more lucrative to launch your own mega projects. Take the Kota works, with its plethora of non-scheduled items bought at exorbitant rates. The project was the vision of a private engineering consultant, who had been named by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the alleged Syndicate Bank fraud case and has harsh comments from the Rajasthan HC and the Supreme Court embellishing his resume. Some engineers who were part of the project say there should have been a public debate on all aspects before work started. Not easy. Last year, Kota collector Harimohan Meena was removed unceremoniously, reportedly for referring an expenditure that was 50 per cent above scheduled rates to a committee rather than approving it quickly. In such a scenario, governments happily go on indulging their penchant for expenditure. Tacky statues whose limbs get stolen. Underpasses that flood during rains—like the one at the Gobriya Bawri circle in Kota. Foot overbridges used rarely by people but which come in handy for advertising signages.

All this is happening in a city that keeps making news for all the wrong reasons. The coaching industry in Kota is synonymous with 24 student suicides till August this year—the highest for any year in under eight months. Kota's medical facilities are breathtakingly bad. In June this year, a lawyer, for want of a wheelchair, drove a scooter right through hospital corridors all the way to the third floor, with his son, left leg plastered, riding pillion. The city often comes in third after Mumbai's Mazgaon and Delhi's ITO for the worst air quality. Once an industrial hub, nearly all major firms have shut their units in Kota in the last two decades.

Circling out beyond town, the gloom deepens. Nearly 10 per cent of about a thousand government schools in the Kota district are in a dilapidated condition. Of the 1,246 anganwadis in the district, 709 have no electricity. All this without even venturing into Rajasthan's 'BIMARU' status on other counts. That's why the political criticism of Dhariwal's dream project has been quite bipartisan, not least for the fact that most of it has been confined to a small part of Kota city that falls in his constituency. "The thousands of crores being spent on cosmetic effects in Kota are at the cost of basic infrastructure elsewhere," Congress's Osian MLA Divya Maderna told INDIA TODAY.

Forget the consequences of bad planning on urban life. In the long term, the environmental damage will be irreversible. Rajendra Singh Sisodia, Magsaysay winner and founder of the NGO Tarun Bharat Sangh, says the riverfront project is mere cosmetic surgery. "They have killed the natural river's beauty by converting it into a channel. I wish they had developed green corridors to strengthen the banks instead." The People's World Commission on Flood and Drought, in turn, points to the pollutants released in the Chambal during the riverfront works, including by a foundry that's making the huge bell. In a sense, that bell tolls ominously for every living form there: a city, a river and a people. ■